

Academic integrity violations in higher education: a systematic literature review from 2013–2023

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Abstract

Purpose – This study aimed to review the different types of academic integrity violations reported in the literature between 2013 and 2023. Moreover, this study investigated the causes of these violations and recommends approaches and measures that can be implemented to minimise academic integrity violations in the era of artificial intelligence (AI).

Design/methodology/approach – We reviewed 27 articles published between 2013 and 2023 from the Scopus database. We followed the reporting guidelines of the Preferred Reporting Items for Systematic Reviews and Meta-Analyses to select, filter, and report relevant studies that met the research objectives.

Findings – The study revealed that various individual, institutional, social, cultural, and technological factors contribute to academic integrity violations. To minimise this issue, higher education institutions should offer brief academic integrity tutorial courses to all first-year students to enhance their knowledge of academic integrity. Moreover, academic honour codes should be regularly reviewed and updated, and technological tools should be implemented to detect AI-generated third-party assignments submitted by students. Furthermore, higher education institutions should frequently conduct training and workshops to educate students on the consequences of violating academic integrity.

Originality/value – This study contributes to existing literature. It highlights the wider societal implications of academic integrity violations such as their influence on workforce readiness and ethical standards in professional environments.

Keywords Academic integrity violations, Honour code, Technology, Artificial intelligence, Academic integrity tutorial, Awareness

Paper type Literature review

Introduction

Academic integrity is foundational in higher education, representing a commitment to ethical principles and behaviours that foster honesty, trust, fairness, and respect in

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educational settings, research, and scholarly endeavours. It encompasses values such as responsibility and courage ([International Center for Academic Integrity \[ICAI\], 2021](#)). Instances of academic integrity violations, such as misrepresentation or intellectual theft, are particularly prevalent in online learning environments compared with traditional classroom settings. [MacLeod and Eaton \(2020\)](#) found that 53.1% of respondents admitted to such violations in an online context.

The proliferation of technology has exacerbated integrity breaches, with students leveraging electronic devices and the Internet's 'cut-and-paste' culture to replicate existing work ([Peytcheva-Forsyth et al., 2018](#)). Artificial intelligence (AI), exemplified by ChatGPT, presents new challenges, including high-tech plagiarism and unethical collaboration ([Gefen and Arinze, 2023](#); [Fergus et al., 2023](#)). Teachers and administrators struggle to distinguish genuine student work from technologically enhanced or collaborative efforts ([Crawford et al., 2023](#)).

The root causes of integrity violations are diverse and are influenced by peer and parental pressures, exam difficulties, and the motivation to achieve high grades ([Mustapha and Ali, 2017](#)). Additionally, motives may stem from low self-esteem, poor time management, heavy workloads, anxiety, and a focus on grades over genuine learning ([Chiam et al., 2021](#)). These factors underscore the intricate interplay between the personal, cultural, and technological factors of academic integrity.

[Thomas \(2017\)](#) examined the factors behind academic integrity violations in individual and cultural contexts. The findings emphasise that personal or group dynamics often influence students' decisions to engage in such violations. For instance, parental pressure to achieve high grades coupled with the observation of peers benefiting from cheating can influence students to follow similar paths. This desire for unauthorised advantages reflects not only the pursuit of better grades but also a preference for completing degrees with minimal effort, neglecting the opportunity for true knowledge and skill development ([Won and Lee, 2023](#)).

This study investigates academic integrity violations in higher education institutions, focusing on various aspects such as leadership dynamics, political orientations, and institutional financial models ([Alam et al., 2022](#)). It also examines the role of political influence in fostering corruption and nepotism within these institutions ([Alam, 2022](#)). Additionally, the study highlights the challenges faced by private higher education institutions in balancing educational principles with business objectives, which often leads to increased competition and subsequent academic integrity violations ([Alam, 2023](#)).

Academic integrity violations are more common among students than among staff and teachers, despite institutions implementing disciplinary actions, such as suspension or expulsion, to address these issues, which have been ineffective ([Chala, 2021](#)). Advancements in technology and the use of AI tools have further complicated efforts to address academic integrity ([Perkins, 2023](#)). Therefore, it is crucial to understand the underlying causes of these violations and develop effective strategies to mitigate them. This systematic review aims to answer several key questions in this area.

- (1) How many scholarly articles addressing academic integrity violations were published between 2013 and 2023?
- (2) What types of academic integrity violations are commonly reported in the literature?
- (3) What are the root causes behind academic integrity violations?
- (4) What interventions and measures can be adopted to mitigate academic integrity violations?

The remainder of this paper is structured as follows: [Section 2](#) critically examines existing and prior research on academic integrity violations to elucidate major insights into the associated issues. [Section 3](#) outlines the study's materials and methods and provides a systematic and logical framework for conducting the analysis. [Section 4](#) presents the findings and discussion and offers comprehensive suggestions and recommendations for addressing the challenges of academic integrity violations. Finally, [Section 5](#) presents the conclusions and discusses the limitations of the study within the broader context of the findings and discussions.

Literature review

Academic integrity is a fundamental aspect of higher education institutions, defined by [Tauginienė et al. \(2018\)](#) as adherence to ethical and professional principles guiding decisions and actions in education, research, and scholarship. [Bleazby \(2020\)](#) underscored the role of institutions in cultivating students' moral and ethical values. Most American parents (97%) support integrating values such as honesty into academic curricula ([Pavela, 1997](#)), emphasising the importance of promoting integrity alongside teaching excellence.

During the COVID-19 pandemic, scholars noted a surge in academic integrity breaches in online classes ([Khan et al., 2021](#)). Online assessments facilitate widespread collaboration among students, transcend geographical barriers and time constraints, and intensify competition for top grades ([Manoharan and Ye, 2020](#)). The standardised nature of online exams allows for easier performance comparisons, tempting academically weaker students to resort to dishonest practices for better scores. Instructors struggle with limited online proctoring tools, hindering accurate evaluation; for instance, students exploit Google searches during advanced placement exams ([Bilen and Matros, 2021](#)).

The integration of teleconferencing facilities and collaboration during exams has become a significant aspect of student interaction in academic settings. According to [Hung et al. \(2024\)](#), there was a notable improvement in students' grades on online post-lecture quizzes compared with pre-lecture assessments. This underscores the importance of ensuring the integrity of online assessments to uphold fair practices for all students, particularly those who abstain from academic dishonesty.

To protect the integrity of online assessment systems, higher education institutions must implement live online proctoring and enforce regulations that require students to activate web video recordings during online exams. Additionally, institutions should develop advanced IT systems to restrict browser access and prevent the use of search engines, such as Google, during examinations. Biometric authentication measures should also be implemented to verify the identities of candidates based on their physiological or behavioural characteristics. Educators should vary exam questions and assessment formats to prevent cheating ([Holden et al., 2021](#)).

Advancements in technology have significantly altered educational practices, though not without unintended consequences, such as increased incidents of cheating and plagiarism among students. While beneficial, AI tools also pose a significant risk to academic integrity in higher education ([Williams and Fadda, 2023](#)). Instances of academic misconduct raise questions about curriculum effectiveness, degree credibility, and graduate competencies ([Cuadrado et al., 2019](#)). The era of Internet technology and AI tools has worsened fraudulent activities within higher education institutions, sparking legitimate concerns among academic stakeholders.

Studies on academic integrity violations have been conducted from various theoretical perspectives. [Khalid et al. \(2020\)](#) applied self-development theory to understand students' motivations for such violations. They discovered that students driven by extrinsic factors

were more likely to cheat in educational settings, while those motivated by intrinsic factors such as autonomy and competence tended to uphold academic integrity.

The repercussions of academic integrity violations extend beyond individuals to institutions, societies, educators, and learners globally. [Freeman *et al.* \(2020\)](#) stressed that credentials obtained without genuine learning can lead to job inefficiency or unemployment. Additionally, students who engage in academic dishonesty may perpetuate this behaviour in their professional lives ([Iberahim *et al.*, 2013](#)), contributing to corporate corruption and unethical practices. This breach also risks normalising unethical conduct among educators and future professionals ([Ayala-Enríquez and Guerrero-Dib, 2024](#)). Hence, it is critical to prioritise the detection and prevention of academic integrity violations to uphold educational objectives and cultivate ethically competent graduates.

Material and methods

This study adhered to the Preferred Reporting Items for Systematic Reviews and Meta-Analyses (PRISMA) guidelines for conducting systematic literature reviews ([Sarkis-Onofre *et al.*, 2021](#)). PRISMA criteria serve as a foundational framework for systematically and transparently articulating and visualising the study's results selection process during the review and meta-analysis ([Surahman and Wang, 2022](#)).

For the purpose of this study, a systematic search strategy was employed to identify relevant articles published between 2013 and 2023 in the Scopus database. Scopus was selected as the primary database owing to its comprehensive coverage of peer-reviewed papers and scientific literature across multiple disciplines. The search strategy focused on key concepts related to academic integrity violations, including academic misconduct, dishonesty, fraud, cheating, and plagiarism in higher education institutions. The search strings employ Boolean operators (AND and OR) to refine and expand the search based on the research questions. Two authors (I and IV) independently conducted a search in Scopus to ensure the reproducibility and transparency of the data retrieval process. The authors included a total of 27 articles that met the inclusion and exclusion criteria for this study ([Figure 1](#)).

Inclusion criteria of the study

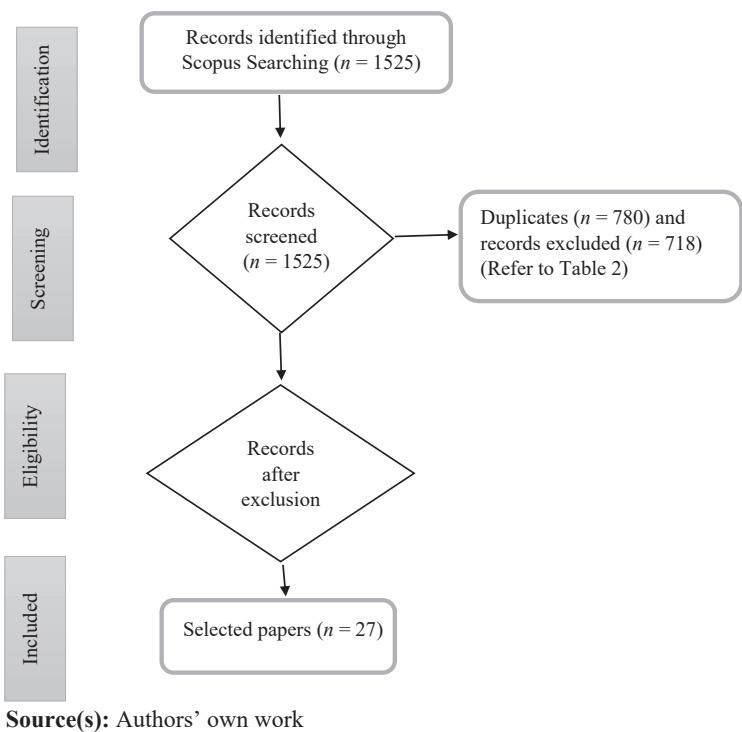
The authors selected papers based on specific inclusion criteria. Articles were included if they met the following criteria:

- (1) Published between 2013 and 2023.
- (2) Published in Scopus-indexed journals.
- (3) Published in the English language.
- (4) Full text available.
- (5) Focused on social sciences.
- (6) Focused on higher education and academic integrity violations.

Screening and selection

Based on the search strings, researchers (I and IV) independently conducted an initial search in the Scopus database, resulting in 1,525 research papers. An Excel spreadsheet was used to store the extracted data, which were then coded to facilitate the subsequent analysis. Second, researcher (I) eliminated duplicate records ($n = 780$) using Excel, while researcher (IV) manually verified and confirmed the authenticity of the papers, ensuring accurate removal of

Figure 1.
PRISMA flowchart for
selecting studies
(Moher *et al.*, 2009)



duplicates. Subsequently, 718 papers were excluded from the database based on the research exclusion criteria (Table 1).

Data extraction

At the final stage, both authors (I and IV) agreed to include 27 research papers. These papers were transferred to Mendeley, a reference management software package. In the subsequent process, a literature review matrix was created, initially ordered by publication year. Each paper was then individually examined to address the research questions systematically and logically and to meet the research objectives.

Table 1.
Number of excluded
papers based on the
exclusion criteria

Exclusion criteria	Number of papers
Duplicate content	780
Books, book chapters, conference papers, conference reviews, editorials, errata, letters, notes, retracted articles, and reviews	237
Articles not written in English	26
Articles with unavailable full text	295
Articles not centred on higher education and academic integrity violations within the specified timeframe	120
Articles outside the realm of social sciences	40
Source(s): Authors' own work	

Synthesis and data analysis

In this study, we adopted thematic and subthematic data analysis approaches. Thematic analysis is a method for identifying, analysing, and reporting patterns (themes) within data (Braun and Clarke, 2006). This type of analysis is inductive, with themes emerging from the data rather than being deductively imposed by the authors. The data were organised based on the research questions. Moreover, the authors used a manual analysis technique to obtain qualitative data and manage and align them with the research topic. It involves data management, including coding, retrieval, sorting, and indexing procedures (Miles and Huberman, 1994).

Data analysis

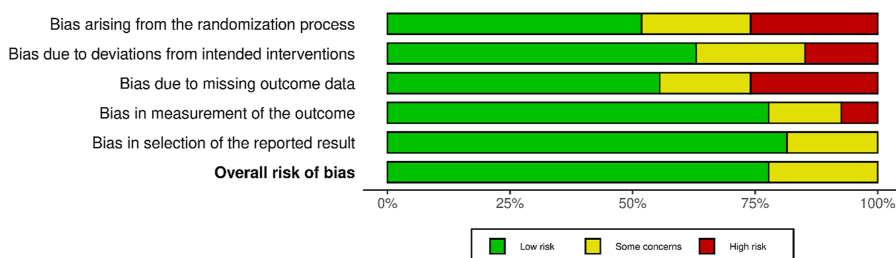
Descriptive analysis was used to pinpoint the general trends in the pertinent literature, including the frequency of academic integrity violations, authorship trends, and research methodology. Moreover, the selected articles were studied to obtain more in-depth information about the reasons academic integrity is violated and how to reduce it. These findings can assist educators and researchers in implementing effective solutions to minimise academic integrity violations in higher education institutions.

Risk bias assessment

In this study, the authors of this paper used the Cochrane 'Risk of bias' tool for randomized trials (RoB 2.0) to conduct a risk of bias assessment (refer to Figure 2) to ensure the authenticity, reliability, and credibility of the study. The authors measured five specific domains in which biases may occur: bias arising from the randomisation process, bias due to deviation from the intended intervention, bias due to missing outcome data, bias in the measurement of the outcome, and bias in the selection of reported results (McGuinness and Higgins, 2021). Two authors (I and IV) independently applied this tool to each included study and categorised the risk of bias as low, moderate, or high. Any conflicts were resolved through discussions to reach an agreement. The authors created a summary of the risk of bias (low, moderate, and high) for each of the included articles. Finally, Robvis software was used to summarise the risk assessment and create a risk chart.

Findings and discussion

Figure 3 illustrates the number of papers selected for this study from 2018 to 2023. The highest number of papers (10) met the inclusion criteria in 2022. In addition, (3) papers were selected from 2021, and (2) papers from 2020. Furthermore, (1) and (2) papers, respectively, met the inclusion criteria from 2014 to 2018.



Source(s): McGuinness and Higgins, 2021, Authors' own work

Figure 2.
Summary of risk bias
assessment ($n = 27$)

From a methodological perspective, scholars have used qualitative, mixed, and quantitative research approaches, as shown in Figure 4, to examine the factors that contribute to academic integrity violations in higher education institutions. The figure shows that 56% of the studies used quantitative research methods, whereas 22% used qualitative and mixed research methods. On the other hand, Figure 4b shows the number of citations generated between 2014 and 2022. According to the data, the highest number of citations (42) was generated in 2019, whereas 37 were generated in 2018. There was a decrease in 2020, but the trend had somewhat stabilised by 2021 and 2022, with modest citation counts of 11 and 7, respectively.

The authorship analysis patterns of the publications are listed in Table 2. The analysis showed that 7% of the database articles were published by female scholars, whereas 4% were published by male scholars. A total of 89% of the papers featured both male and female scholars. Additionally, the study revealed that 11% of the publications had a single author, and 89% had two or more authors.

The findings of this review suggest that there are multiple categories of violations of academic integrity in higher education. The predominant forms of violations were cheating and plagiarism. The themes related to the different types of academic integrity violations are outlined in Table 3.

Figure 3.
The volume of
published journal
articles ($n = 27$)

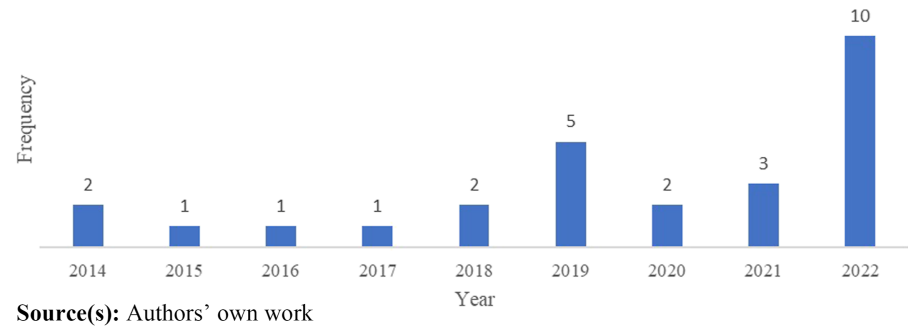
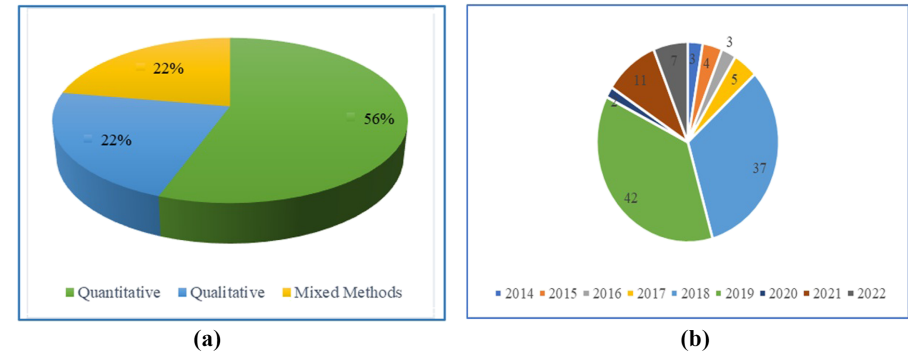


Figure 4.
(a) Distribution of
articles by research
methods (b) Year-wise
citations ($n = 27$)



Causes of academic integrity violations

The findings revealed a range of causes of academic integrity violations. All themes identified in this review are shown in [Table 4](#). These themes were subdivided into five major categories that were further classified into individual, institutional, social, cultural, technological, and demographic factors.

The findings of the study propose several approaches and strategies to reduce academic integrity violations, which are shown in [Table 5](#). These include academic integrity education training, student engagement, ethical awareness, policy development, investigation and consequences, technology enhancement, software development, and anti-plagiarism.

The current study aims to examine the causes of breaches in academic integrity within higher education through a systematic review of pertinent literature and propose potential

Authorship	Author's gender			
Single-authored	Co-authored	Male	Female	Mixed
11 %	89%	7%	4%	89%
Source(s): Authors' own work				

Table 2.
Analysis of authorship patterns

Themes related to types of academic integrity violations	Paper code
Cheating, contract cheating, plagiarism, collusion, falsification, unexpected excuses	SL1, SL2, SL3, SL4, SL5, SL6, SL7, SL9, SL10, SL11, SL14, SL17, SL23, SL24, SL26, SL27
Source(s): Authors' own work	

Table 3.
Themes related to different types of academic integrity violations

Themes	Paper codes
Low awareness of copyright; Teaching methods; Poor teacher and student relationships; Weak academic policies; Misuse of technology; Lack of motivation to study; Societal, cultural, and financial pressures; Helping others; Peer pressure; Learning environment; Excessive stress; Competition; Fear of academic penalties; Pursuit of high scores	SL1, SL2, SL3, SL6, SL7, SL8, SL9, SL10, SL11, SL12, SL13, SL14, SL15, SL16, SL17, SL18, SL19, SL24, SL25, SL27
Source(s): Authors' own work	

Table 4.
Themes associated with increased academic integrity violations

Themes	Paper code
Academic integrity education, training, and workshops; Students' engagement; Ethical awareness; Social and ethical development programmes; Ethical policies and guidelines; Pedagogical approach; Rules and strict punishments; Different tests and evaluations; Improvement of technology; Policy development	SL1, SL2, SL3, SL5, SL6, SL7, SL8, SL9, SL10, SL11, SL12, SL13, SL15, SL16, SL18, SL19, SL20, SL22, SL23, SL24, SL25, SL27
Source(s): Authors' own work	

Table 5.
Themes associated with reduced academic integrity violations

solutions. It presents a contemporary perspective by focusing on how students misuse technology and AI in academic dishonesty.

This study identified the key themes related to the research questions and revealed three primary areas. The first theme, linked to research question 2, explores different types of academic integrity violations. The second theme, corresponding to research question three, investigates the underlying reasons for these breaches. Finally, the third theme addresses research question four, discussing strategies and interventions for combating academic integrity violations.

Various forms of academic integrity violations have been reported, including cheating, contract cheating, plagiarism, collusion, academic misconduct, falsification, and unexcused absence. Cheating involves the use of unauthorised aids or unethical methods to gain unfair advantages in assignments or exams. Contract cheating occurs when a third party completes academic work on behalf of a student, who submits it independently. Plagiarism involves claiming credit for someone else's ideas without proper acknowledgement. The use of the Internet and AI tools has led to emerging violations such as conspiracy theories and falsification. Collusion occurs when students collaborate on tasks that should be independent, whereas falsification involves unauthorised alterations or information reporting. Unexcused absence refers to missing educational activities that do not comply with university policies (Nushi and Firoozkahi, 2017; Medway *et al.*, 2018; Eaton *et al.*, 2019).

The second theme focuses on the causes of academic integrity violations in higher education institutions, grouped into five key categories: individual, institutional, social, cultural, and technological.

Violations of academic integrity are often related to students' lack of motivation. Intrinsically motivated students dedicate more time to their studies and are less prone to academic dishonesty. Conversely, those driven by extrinsic factors may be less attentive in class, rely more on others for assignments, compromise ethical standards, or cheat. Furthermore, integrity breaches stem from knowledge gaps, grade pressure, exam stress, laziness, course complexity, a disregard for rules, financial incentives, and employer cumulative grade point demands. Research indicates that disinterest in studies, poor time management, and unrealistic grade expectations contribute to institutional issues such as ethical lapses and strained teacher-student relationships (Valzadeh, 2022).

Institutional factors significantly influence academic integrity. The institutional environment encompasses the classroom atmosphere, academic policies, and institutional resources that shape student learning and conduct. A positive learning environment fosters ethical behaviour and skill development for academic and professional success. Conversely, negative academic settings characterised by excessive pressure, unrealistic expectations, weak teacher-student relationships, and unethical institutional practices contribute to academic integrity violations. Notably, issues such as low awareness of copyright and intellectual property rights, ineffective teaching methodologies, and the absence of systematic instruction have been highlighted as primary institutional contributors to academic integrity breaches, particularly plagiarism and cheating (Beketov and Lebedeva, 2022).

To address academic integrity violations, several studies have examined the underlying institutional and social factors that contribute to such misconduct. Habiburrahim *et al.* (2021) pointed out that high teacher expectations, stringent assignment deadlines, and poor teacher-student relationships are institutional causes of academic misconduct. Anohina-Naumeca *et al.* (2020) supported these findings by identifying students' lack of awareness of university policies and the absence of systematic approaches to promoting academic integrity as key reasons for violations. Additionally, the absence of clear institutional policies and consistent efforts to educate students about the consequences of academic misconduct significantly contributes to integrity breaches (Kassim *et al.*, 2015).

Social factors, particularly social norms and trust, influence violations of academic integrity. Social norms, representing accepted beliefs, attitudes, and behaviours within specific groups or cultures, affect behaviours across various contexts such as education, family, peers, societal expectations, finances, and social skills. Cuadrado *et al.* (2019) illustrated that students from diverse social, economic, and educational backgrounds exhibit different behaviours related to academic integrity owing to these social influences. In higher education settings, the lack of explicit institutional guidelines and policies on academic integrity is a significant social factor contributing to violations.

Moreover, academic culture, which is influenced by parental pressure for academic success, can lead students to compromise their integrity to meet the high standards set by their parents. Combined with unrealistic expectations and challenging tasks, this pressure can drive students towards dishonest behaviour, even if they are unaware of their true capabilities. Institutional pressures, such as teachers setting high performance expectations, can also incentivise cheating, as students fear that they will not achieve respectable grades otherwise, contributing to a culture of misconduct over time (Olusola, 2020).

Previously uncommon academic integrity breaches have become more prevalent due to the expansion of digital resources. With widespread internet access and advanced technologies such as AI, students now have easy access to abundant information, leading to behaviours such as copying from the internet and utilising essay mills for assignments, which pose challenges for higher education institutions (Medway *et al.*, 2018; Ison and Szathmari, 2016). Students must also understand intellectual property and its fair use. Leveraging technology and AI is critical for fostering ethical learning environments.

To address these challenges, the strategies proposed by researchers (referenced in Table 5) focus on three key areas: pedagogical methods, academic policy enhancement, and technological progress. Implementing an ethics program for students is a proactive step towards promoting academic integrity and preventing misconduct.

Introducing an ethical program for students

Higher education institutions aim to equip students with not only technical skills, but also moral principles that are essential for academic integrity (Cuadrado *et al.*, 2019). Research suggests that imposing punishment alone is ineffective in reducing academic violations. Therefore, institutions must introduce academic integrity tutorials to emphasise ethical values. These courses should cover topics such as academic integrity, institutional codes, the consequences of violations, and moral norms in academia (Anohina-Naumeca *et al.*, 2020). Making academic integrity courses mandatory for new students can foster greater awareness and intolerance towards violations. Studies have shown that comprehensive programs can significantly reduce plagiarism rates (Vaccino-Salvadore and Hull-Buck, 2021).

Universities should adopt institutional strategies, including workshops and awareness events for staff and students (Ison and Szathmari, 2016). Increasing academic integrity lectures within study programs ensures a thorough understanding of university regulations (Valizadeh, 2022). Teachers should employ diverse assessments and proctored examinations to deter violations (Davies and Al Sharefeen, 2022). This holistic approach supports ethical development and reduces academic misconduct effectively.

Development of an academic honour code and policy

The academic honour code serves as a vital framework for universities, guiding their responses to breaches of academic integrity. Institutions must regularly revise their policies to manage such incidents effectively. Students often commit plagiarism because of an insufficient awareness of its consequences (Akbar and Picard, 2019). Educating students on academic conduct and updating the honour code accordingly is crucial. Regular

communication and enforcement are key to fostering a culture of integrity among students (Merkel, 2022). To bolster comprehension and adherence to the honour code, universities should offer training, expand lectures on integrity, and provide counselling through academic advisors (Shala *et al.*, 2018).

Development of an anti-plagiarism software and technology

Technological advancements have led to an increase in undetected academic integrity violations among students. Higher education institutions must invest in technology to safeguard online assessment systems. This includes implementing digital proctoring systems to monitor and record students' actions during exams (Valzadeh, 2022).

Despite its potential misuse for academic dishonesty such as plagiarism, AI software has driven the advancement of more robust plagiarism detection tools. Students exploit AI to stealthily complete assignments and may engage third parties in producing reports, making originality verification challenging for educators. Requiring submissions through plagiarism checkers can mitigate this issue. Prominent tools, such as Turnitin, Authenticare, and Plagiarism Checker, aid this effort. Institutions must prioritise investing in such tools to effectively identify instances of academic dishonesty (Waigand, 2019; Khan *et al.*, 2021). Assessments should reflect individual student efforts and discourage dependency on ghostwriters (Nushi and Firoozkahi, 2017). Such strategies foster academic integrity and reduce plagiarism.

Broader societal implications

The broader societal implications of academic integrity violations are profound and affect students' personal, professional, and societal growth. The dishonest acquisition of educational credentials can result in job inefficiency or even unemployment (Kassim *et al.*, 2015). Research indicates that individuals who engage in academic dishonesty are more prone to unethical behaviour in professional settings, contributing to corporate corruption and unethical practices (Anohina-Naumeca *et al.*, 2020).

Academic integrity violations pose significant challenges by setting negative examples for educators, students, and researchers, potentially fostering similar misconduct within their fields and undermining the credibility of academic degrees (Cuadrado *et al.*, 2019). To address these concerns and safeguard stakeholder interests, it is vital to prioritise the identification and prevention of such violations. Higher education institutions must regularly evaluate and update their academic integrity policies to ensure that students are well informed (Verhoef *et al.*, 2022). Additionally, institutions should provide integrity tutorials, training sessions, and workshops to enhance students' understanding of academic writing and the consequences of its breaches (Srirejeki *et al.*, 2022). Implementing anti-plagiarism software and fostering an ethical educational environment that values fairness in assessing students' work are crucial institutional measures (Beketov and Lebedeva, 2022).

Conclusion

Academic integrity violations stem from various factors, including student disinterest, lack of motivation, poor time management, and unrealistic grade expectations. Institutional deficiencies also contribute to the absence of ethical practices, strained teacher-student relationships, stringent deadlines, outdated policies, and inadequate technology for detecting cheating (Ison and Szathmary, 2016).

Social and cultural influences such as parental pressure, societal recognition, and peer approval also play a role. Technological factors include inappropriate technology use, AI tools, and outsourcing assignments (Khoo and Kang, 2022).

To address these issues, higher education institutions should enhance student motivation by engaging in lectures and developing better teacher-student relationships. Therefore, it is crucial to improve academic writing skills. Regular updates to honour codes and awareness-raising training sessions are essential (Beketov and Lebedeva, 2022). Additionally, investing in technological enhancements and anti-plagiarism software is vital (Nushi and Firoozkoti, 2017). Finally, creating a supportive learning environment that promotes student development and active participation is crucial (Cuadrado *et al.*, 2019).

Limitations and recommendations for future research

This study has several limitations. First, it relied exclusively on the Scopus database, potentially overlooking relevant literature from other sources. Second, it concentrated solely on social sciences, possibly neglecting interdisciplinary perspectives and insights. Third, it spanned only a 10-year period (2013–2023), which may not fully capture the enduring trends or historical contexts crucial for understanding academic integrity breaches in higher education. Future research should investigate how students' perceptions of academic integrity violations have evolved using diverse search terms, timeframes, and databases.

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